



Boston University School of Public Health

PH784 Advanced Social Epidemiology: Methods

Fall 2025

2 Credits

CTC 460

Mondays 10am-12:50pm

Instructor information

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Office location: Talbot 420East

Office hours: Fridays 12-1pm (in person or [zoom](#))

Course description

Methodological rigor is essential for social epidemiology to improve our understanding of social determinants of health and to inform interventions and policies that enhance health equity. Improving the methodological rigor of social epidemiologic research requires understanding the unique challenges and questions of interest in social epidemiology. This course covers key factors we need to consider to critically consume evidence from the social epidemiologic literature and to identify gaps for future research. This course is not intended to be a general epidemiologic methods course. Rather, this course provides an overview of recent discussions on methodological issues specific to social epidemiology.

Course learning objectives

Upon completion of this course, students will be able to:

1. Identify causal inference challenges that are unique to social epidemiology and explain implications of these challenges, and potential solutions
2. Choose the most appropriate method for their questions of interest by considering strengths and weaknesses of analytical approaches that are commonly used in social epidemiology
3. Critically evaluate methodology of published social epidemiologic studies and identify knowledge gaps for future research
4. Propose the application of modern methods to answer questions that are unique to social epidemiology

Learning resources

Textbook: None

Software: The course requires the RStudio statistical computing package. Our installation guide is available on Blackboard. Here are the instructions in brief:

- Point your browser to www.r-project.org, click on CRAN (underneath Download), choose a server (Linux, Windows, or Mac), and follow the instructions in the "Download and install R" box.
 1. Open the link, click Download for R for ".." and choose the version you want (Linux, Windows, or Mac).

2. Next, go to the version appropriate for your computer. For Macs, choose the version appropriate to your processor: Intel or Apple Silicon (M1 or M2). You can check the chip through "About this Mac" in the Apple menu.
 3. Click on the link for the package and download the package file to your computer.
 4. Open the package file and follow the directions.
- RStudio can be downloaded and installed from: <https://www.rstudio.com/>
Choose the appropriate server to install RStudio; this should be done before the first class.

The teaching team will be available in EB-43 on Monday, 9/9, at 9:30 am before the first class session for installation assistance. All datasets are available on Blackboard.

Course Website: The course Blackboard Learn website is accessible via <https://learn.bu.edu>. All students are expected to obtain a BU e-mail account and password in order to be able to access the website. The website will enable students to communicate with each other via e-mail, check announcements, link to the assigned readings, and view lecture slides. Weekly discussion posts will also be conducted through Blackboard.

Teaching methodology/Course format

This course mainly consists of a series of pedagogic lectures on social epidemiologic methods. The lectures are coupled with in-class quizzes and discussions. Each week, students will work on an assignment that involves critical reading of published social epidemiologic studies based on what they learned from the lecture. The assignment will also involve the analysis of real-world data and interpretation of results. Students will discuss their thinking on the assignment during the lecture in the following week.

Assessments

Class Participation: Participation in class discussions.

Reading Quizzes: Each week, a 5-question multiple choice reading quiz based on the required readings will be posted. Responses to the reading quizzes will be due before the beginning of each class session.

Weekly Problem set: Each week, students will work on an assignment that involves critical reading of published social epidemiologic studies based on what they learned from the lecture. The assignment will also involve the analysis of real-world data. The focus of this data analysis task will be on interpreting results rather than coding. Students will have access to R codes that they can use to complete the assignment with some minor modifications. Although there will be no problem set covering the last topic (mediation), students will receive R codes to implement the methods in their own projects.

Final Paper: Students will submit a final paper that will be due at the end of the course. In response to prompts, this paper summarizes their critical evaluations of published social epidemiologic articles in terms of various aspects covered in this course, except for the one to be taught in the last week of the course (mediation). Students will act as if they were a peer-reviewer assigned to the article and provide critical yet constructive feedback.

Grading policy

The overall grade for the class will be derived as follows:

Assessment	% Grade
Class Participation	10%
Weekly Reading Quiz	10%
Weekly Problem Set	60%
Final Paper	20%
Total	100%

Students will be assigned the following final letter grades, based on course assessments. All SPH candidates must have a minimum 3.0 GPA at SPH to graduate. Please review the full Boston University School of Public Health [grading policy](#).

Course	Final
94-100	A
90-93	A-
87-89	B+
83-86	B
80-82	B-
77-79	C+
73-76	C
70-72	C-
60-69	D
<60	F

Expectations of ourselves at our best.

We all aim to:

- Strive for excellence
- Exercise the highest integrity in all aspects of work
- Be open, flexible, realistic, and understanding
- Demonstrate professionalism and trustworthiness as a representative of Boston University and the School of Public Health
- Understand and follow the policies and procedures of Boston University and of the School of Public Health

We will be guided by five behaviors, with corresponding expectations of ourselves for each behavior:

Behavior	Expectations
Engagement	• Embrace responsibility for our work, learning, and all other activities • Work responsibly and collaboratively
Collaboration	• Receive constructive feedback from faculty, teaching assistants, mentors and others • Openly share expertise and experience to assure individual and team success
Communication	• Provide feedback to faculty, teaching assistants, mentors and others • Seek support when needed • Use technology in a responsible and professional manner

Respect for others	• Respect the unique cultures, strengths, viewpoints and experiences of others • Show compassion and tolerance • Participate in community and classroom discussions and activities
Helping others succeed	• Reach out to others who appear to be struggling • Seek ways to contribute to the success of others

Course policies and student expectations

- Late-work policy: Assignments turned in late will be given a grade of 0. Please contact Prof. Shiba in advance if you anticipate any exceptional circumstances.
- Generative AI policy: Learning is often a challenging and iterative process, but it results in a deeper understanding and the development of new skills. This process can be facilitated by using generative AI tools, including but not limited to ChatGPT, Claude, Copilot, Gemini, etc. However, the use of these tools can also be counterproductive and inhibit your learning. In this course, you may use these tools for proofreading (e.g., checking spelling and grammar, improving clarity and conciseness of text that you structure and draft by yourself). Students are strongly discouraged from directly asking for answers to reading quizzes, problem sets, or the final paper. This is not only because it would not be good for your learning but also because those answers are most likely imperfect and can lead to lower grades. Although most of the problem sets can be completed by slightly modifying the sample R code that will be provided to students, students may use AI tools to help with their coding as they see fit.
- Attendance and/or participation policy: Students must obtain prior permission from the instructors in order to have an excused absence from class for other than medical reasons
- Technology in the classroom: Computers may be used in class only when an instructor is lecturing or students are instructed to look material up online.

Boston University School of Public Health: Standards of Academic Honesty

Students in the School of Public Health are expected to adhere to the highest standards of academic honesty. Academic honesty is essential for students to attain the competencies the School expects of its graduates and to enable the faculty to adequately assess student performance. Any action by a student that subverts these goals seriously undermines the integrity of the educational programs of the School.

Academic misconduct is any intentional act or omission by a student which misrepresents his or her academic achievements, or any attempt to misrepresent his or her academic achievements. The following acts constitute academic misconduct. This is not an exhaustive list.

- *Cheating on examinations*: The use or attempted use of any unauthorized books, notes or other materials in order to enhance the student's performance in the examination, copying or attempting to copy from another student's examination, permitting another student to copy from an examination or otherwise assisting another student during an examination, or any other violation of the examination's stated or commonly understood ground rules.
- *Plagiarism*: Any representation of the work of another as one's own constitutes

plagiarism. This includes copying or substantially restating the work of another person without the use of quotation marks or other indication that the words of another have been copied, the use of any written or oral work from which the student has obtained ideas or data without citing the source, or collaborating with another person in an academic endeavor without acknowledging that person's contribution.

- *Submitting the same work in more than one course without the consent of all the instructors*
- *Misrepresentation or falsification of data*
- *Allowing another student to represent your work as his or her own*
- *Violating the rules of an examination or assignment*

A student who is found guilty of academic misconduct may be subject to disciplinary action, up to and including dismissal from the School. For more details, please review the [full policy](#). Be sure to complete the [plagiarism tutorial](#) and review [tips for avoiding academic dishonesty](#).

Fall 2025 Course Schedule

Session	Date	Topic	Assignments Due
1	Sep 8	Course Overview/Descriptive Social Epidemiology	Reading quiz 1 (Optional)
2	Sep 15	Causal Inference Challenges in Social Epi	Reading quiz 2; Weekly PS 1 (descriptive epi)
3	Sep 22	Causal Inference Challenges in Social Epi (continued)	Reading quiz 3; Weekly PS 2 (causal inference)
4	Sep 29	Data and Measurements in Social Epidemiology	Reading quiz 4; Weekly PS 3 (causal inference)
5	Oct 6	Causal Estimand in Social Epidemiology	Reading quiz 5; Weekly PS 4 (data, measurement)
6	Oct 14 (substitute)	Interaction and Effect Heterogeneity	Reading quiz 6; Weekly PS 5 (causal estimand)
7	Oct 20	Mediation	Reading quiz 7; Weekly PS 6 (interaction - OPTIONAL); Final paper

Session outline

Class #1: Course Overview/Descriptive Social Epidemiology

Description: This session begins with a brief overview of course objectives, a working agreement for the course, and introductions to social epidemiologic inquiries. We will then review the major

concepts and methods in descriptively measuring health disparities.

At the end of this session, students will be able to:

- Classify key typology of social epidemiologic inquiries and their purposes
- Explain the importance of questioning the research questions based on theories
- Select measures of health disparity based on their pros and cons
- Critically evaluate the literature that reports the magnitudes of health disparities

Readings:

Required Reading:

- Braveman P. Health disparities and health equity: concepts and measurement. (2006) Annu Rev Public Health, 27:167-194.
- Harper S, Lynch J. Health inequalities: measurement and decomposition. Methods in social epidemiology. 2017 Mar 20;2.
 - PDF version available at SSRN: https://papers.ssrn.com/sol3/papers.cfm?abstract_id=2887311
 - A comprehensive overview of health disparity metrics

Optional reading:

- Fox MP, Murray EJ, Lesko CR, Sealy-Jefferson S. On the need to revitalize descriptive epidemiology. American journal of epidemiology. 2022 Jul;191(7):1174-9.
- Mackenbach, & Kunst. (1997). Measuring the magnitude of socio-economic inequalities in health: An overview of available measures illustrated with two examples from Europe. Social Science & Medicine, 44(6), 757-771.
 - This is a real-world application of SII/RII for assessing health disparities.

Assignment:

- Readings

Class #2: Causal Inference Challenges in Social Epi

Description: In this session, we will begin with the brief review of causal inference based on observational data. Students will then learn challenges in causal inference that are unique to social epidemiology such as manipulability of social exposures.

At the end of this session, students will be able to:

- Identify potential weakness of published studies on social determinants of health
- Identify assumptions underlying a regression model and suggest alternative approaches
- Describe consistency and positivity assumptions in causal identification and how they may be violated in social epidemiologic studies

Readings:

Required Reading:

- Galea S, Hernán MA. Win-win: reconciling social epidemiology and causal inference. American journal of epidemiology. 2020 Mar 2;189(3):167-70.
- Rehkopf DH, Glymour MM, Osypuk TL. The consistency assumption for causal inference in social epidemiology: when a rose is not a rose. Current epidemiology reports. 2016 Mar;3(1):63-71.

Optional reading:

- Commentaries for Galea & Hernan (2020)
 - e.g., VanderWeele TJ. Invited commentary: counterfactuals in social epidemiology—thinking outside of “the box”. American Journal of Epidemiology. 2020 Mar 2;189(3):175-8.
- Hernán MA. Does water kill? A call for less casual causal inferences. Annals of epidemiology. 2016 Oct 1;26(10):674-80.
- Kaufman JS. Commentary: causal inference for social exposures. Annual review of public health. 2019 Apr 1;40(1):7-21.
- Hernán MA, VanderWeele TJ. Compound treatments and transportability of causal inference. Epidemiology. 2011 May 1;22(3):368-77.
- VanderWeele TJ, Hernan MA. Causal inference under multiple versions of treatment. Journal of causal inference. 2013 May 29;1(1):1-20.
- Rudolph KE, Williams NT, Miles CH, Antonelli J, Diaz I. All models are wrong, but which are useful? Comparing parametric and nonparametric estimation of causal effects in finite samples. Journal of Causal Inference. 2023 Nov 27;11(1):20230022.

Assignment:

- Readings
- Reading quizzes
- R problem set

Class #3: Causal Inference Challenges in Social Epi (continued)

Description: We will learn alternative approaches to causal identification commonly used in social epidemiology: between-comparison based on covariate adjustment, within-comparison using fixed regression, and quasi-random methods.

At the end of this session, students will be able to:

- Select covariates based on the principles of confounder selection
- Critically yet constructively interpret causal social epi studies that are likely with unmeasured confounders and selection bias
- Interpret findings from fixed effects and quasi-random approaches while acknowledging their key assumptions as well as pros and cons.
- Explain why there is no “hierarchy” in these different approaches

Readings:

Required Reading:

- VanderWeele TJ. Principles of confounder selection. European journal of epidemiology. 2019 Mar 15;34:211-9.
- Krieger N, Davey Smith G. The tale wagged by the DAG: broadening the scope of causal inference and explanation for epidemiology. International journal of epidemiology. 2016 Dec 1;45(6):1787-808.

Optional reading:

- Commentaries for Krieger & Davey Smith (2016)
 - e.g., VanderWeele TJ. Commentary: on causes, causal inference, and potential outcomes. International journal of epidemiology. 2016 Dec 1;45(6):1809-16.
- Imbens GW. Potential outcome and directed acyclic graph approaches to causality: Relevance for empirical practice in economics. Journal of Economic Literature. 2020 Dec 1;58(4):1129-79.
 - Critiques of DAGs by an econometrician. Do you buy their arguments?

- Hernán MA, Hernández-Díaz S, Robins JM. A structural approach to selection bias. *Epidemiology*. 2004 Sep 1;15(5):615-25.
- VanderWeele TJ, Ding P. Sensitivity analysis in observational research: introducing the E-value. *Annals of internal medicine*. 2017 Aug 15;167(4):268-74.
- Hernán MA, Robins JM. Instruments for causal inference: an epidemiologist's dream?. *Epidemiology*. 2006 Jul 1;17(4):360-72.
- Shiba K, Kawahara T. Using propensity scores for causal inference: pitfalls and tips. *Journal of epidemiology*. 2021 Aug 5;31(8):457-63.
 - On similarities and differences between various propensity score methods in terms of causal assumptions, modeling assumptions, and causal estimand under consideration.

Assignment:

- Readings
- Reading quizzes
- R problem set

Class #4: Data and Measurements in Social Epidemiology

Description: Strong study design and fancy statistical methods alone do not ensure good causal inference. Good causal inference requires good data. In this session, students will learn about the importance of high-quality measurements for scientific rigor and properties of good measures. We will then discuss more specific measurements commonly used in social epidemiologic studies, including socioeconomic status and neighborhood characteristics. The session also provides an overview of common and emerging data sources in social epidemiologic research, along with their strengths and limitations.

At the end of this session, students will be able to:

- Explain what the validity and reliability of measurements are
- Explain the implications of measurement errors in social epidemiologic research
- Select measures of socioeconomic status based on their strengths and limitations
- Critically evaluate the operationalization of neighborhood measurements in the literature

Readings:

Required Reading:

- Arcaya MC, Tucker-Seeley RD, Kim R, Schnake-Mahl A, So M, Subramanian SV. Research on neighborhood effects on health in the United States: a systematic review of study characteristics. *Social science & medicine*. 2016 Nov 1;168:16-29.
- Oakes JM, Rossi PH. The measurement of SES in health research: current practice and steps toward a new approach. *Social science & medicine*. 2003 Feb 1;56(4):769-84.

Optional reading:

- Hernán MA, VanderWeele TJ. Compound treatments and transportability of causal inference. *Epidemiology*. 2011 May 1;22(3):368-77.
- Krieger N, Smith K, Naishadham D, Hartman C, Barbeau EM. Experiences of discrimination: validity and reliability of a self-report measure for population health research on racism and health. *Social science & medicine*. 2005 Oct 1;61(7):1576-96.
- Kwan MP. The uncertain geographic context problem. *Annals of the Association of American Geographers*. 2012 Sep 1;102(5):958-68.
- Fotheringham AS, Wong DW. The modifiable areal unit problem in multivariate statistical analysis. *Environment and planning A*. 1991 Jul;23(7):1025-44.
- VanderWeele TJ, Batty CJ. On the dimensional indeterminacy of one-wave factor analysis under causal effects. *Journal of Causal Inference*. 2023 Jul 28;11(1):20220074.

Assignment:

- Readings
- Reading quizzes
- R problem set

Class #5: Causal Estimand in Social Epidemiology

Description: Causal inference is not just about removing bias and estimating effects better based on observational data. The critical step in causal inference is to specify which “effects” (i.e., causal estimand) to estimate to begin with. This session will examine various types of causal estimands relevant to social epidemiology, reviewing their mathematical definitions, estimation approaches, and application examples.

At the end of this session, students will be able to:

- Identify causal estimand of published or own studies and translate it to mathematical notations
- Go beyond population average treatment effect paradigm and consider alternative estimands that may be more relevant to questions of interest
- Explain when time-varying treatment analysis is truly needed in social epidemiology, where most exposures are time-varying in nature

Readings:

Required Reading:

- Westreich, D. From patients to policy: population intervention effects in epidemiology. *Epidemiology*. 2017 July; 28(4):525-528.
- Shiba K, Torres JM, Daoud A, Inoue K, Kanamori S, Tsuji T, Kamada M, Kondo K, Kawachi I. Estimating the impact of sustained social participation on depressive symptoms in older adults. *Epidemiology*. 2021 Nov 1;32(6):886-95.

Optional reading:

- Lundberg I, Johnson R, Stewart BM. What is your estimand? Defining the target quantity connects statistical evidence to theory. *American Sociological Review*. 2021 Jun;86(3):532-65.
- Lundberg I. The gap-closing estimand: A causal approach to study interventions that close disparities across social categories. *Sociological Methods & Research*. 2024 May;53(2):507-70.
- Ahern J, Hubbard A, Galea S. Estimating the effects of potential public health interventions on population disease burden: a step-by-step illustration of causal inference methods. *American journal of epidemiology*. 2009 May 1;169(9):1140-7.
- Rudolph JE, Cartus A, Bodnar LM, Schisterman EF, Naimi AI. The role of the natural course in causal analysis. *American journal of epidemiology*. 2022 Feb;191(2):341-8.
- Hu FB. Dietary pattern analysis: a new direction in nutritional epidemiology. *Current opinion in lipidology*. 2002 Feb 1;13(1):3-9. (*Consider how their argument may apply to social epidemiology!)
 - Shiba K, Hanazato M, Aida J, Kondo K, Arcaya M, James P, Kawachi I. Cardiometabolic profiles and change in neighborhood food and built environment among older adults: a natural experiment. *Epidemiology*. 2020 Nov 1;31(6):758-67.
- VanderWeele TJ, Mathur MB, Chen Y. Outcome-wide longitudinal designs for causal inference: a new template for empirical studies. *Statistical Science*. 2020 August; 35(3):437-466

Assignment:

- Readings
- Reading quizzes
- R problem set

Class #6: Interaction and Effect Heterogeneity

Description: The health effects of social determinants likely differ across individuals and communities. We will discuss why and how to assess such effect heterogeneity. This session covers both traditional and novel machine-learning-based approaches for assessing effect heterogeneity.

At the end of this session, students will be able to:

- Explain the distinction between effect modification/effect heterogeneity and causal interaction
- Identify key assumptions to examine effect modification/effect heterogeneity and causal interaction
- Explain the importance of scales in assessing effect modification/effect heterogeneity
- Explain the definition of conditional average treatment effects and its role in assessing effect heterogeneity
- Identify an appropriate method for assessing effect heterogeneity by considering the strengths and limitations of alternative approaches

Readings:

Required Reading:

- VanderWeele TJ, Knol MJ. A tutorial on interaction. Epidemiologic methods. 2014 Dec 1;3(1):33-72.
- Ward JB, Gartner DR, Keyes KM, Fliss MD, McClure ES, Robinson WR. How do we assess a racial disparity in health? Distribution, interaction, and interpretation in epidemiological studies. Annals of epidemiology. 2019 Jan 1;29:1-7.

Optional reading:

- Shiba K, Inoue K. Harnessing causal forests for epidemiologic research: key considerations. American Journal of Epidemiology. 2024 Jun;193(6):813-8.
- Shiba K, Daoud A, Hikichi H, Yazawa A, Aida J, Kondo K, Kawachi I. Heterogeneity in cognitive disability after a major disaster: A natural experiment study. Science advances. 2021 Sep 29;7(40):eabj2610.
- Cintron DW, Adler NE, Gottlieb LM, Hagan E, Tan ML, Vlahov D, Glymour MM, Matthay EC. Heterogeneous treatment effects in social policy studies: an assessment of contemporary articles in the health and social sciences. Annals of epidemiology. 2022 Jun 1;70:79-88.

Assignment:

- Readings
- Reading quizzes
- R problem set

Class #7: Mediation

Description: Mediation analysis has increasingly been used in epidemiologic research to study intermediate pathways linking exposures and health outcomes. This session will review the theoretical basis and examples of applications of mediation analysis that have provided insights unique to social epidemiologic research questions.

At the end of this session, students will be able to:

- Explain various types of causal mediation analysis and underlying assumptions
- Apply mediation analysis to decompose the association between social characteristics (e.g., race and ethnicity) and health to identify the target of interventions for mitigating health disparities
- Apply mediation analysis to strengthen theories in life-course epidemiology

Readings:

Required Reading:

- Nguyen TQ, Schmid I, Stuart EA. Clarifying causal mediation analysis for the applied researcher: Defining effects based on what we want to learn. *Psychological Methods*. 2021 Apr;26(2):255.
- Jackson JW, VanderWeele TJ. Decomposition analysis to identify intervention targets for reducing disparities. *Epidemiology*. 2018 Nov 1;29(6):825-35.

Optional reading:

- Naimi AI, Schnitzer ME, Moodie EE, Bodnar LM. Mediation analysis for health disparities research. *American journal of epidemiology*. 2016 Aug 15;184(4):315-24.
- Nandi A, Glymour MM, Kawachi I, VanderWeele TJ. Using marginal structural models to estimate the direct effect of adverse childhood social conditions on onset of heart disease, diabetes, and stroke. *Epidemiology*. 2012 Mar 1;23(2):223-32.
- Yazawa A, Shiba K, Inoue Y, Okuzono SS, Inoue K, Kondo N, Kondo K, Kawachi I. Early childhood adversity and late-life depressive symptoms: unpacking mediation and interaction by adult socioeconomic status. *Social psychiatry and psychiatric epidemiology*. 2022 Jun;57(6):1147-56.
- VanderWeele TJ. Invited commentary: structural equation models and epidemiologic analysis. *American journal of epidemiology*. 2012 Oct 1;176(7):608-12.

Assignment:

- Readings
- Reading quizzes
- R problem set (Optional)
- Final paper

BUSPH Academic Support Resources

There are many support resources available to BUSPH students, including [communication resources](#), a [writing guide](#), [academic support](#) and a [core course tutoring program](#). For more information, contact Ryann Monteiro at sphtutor@bu.edu.

Public Health Writing Program

The Public Health Writing Program is available to SPH degree candidates who would like to discuss planning a paper, organizing a paper, writing clearly, or other aspects of the writing process. The program is not an editing service and does not guarantee that the assistant will be knowledgeable about content of the paper.

For more information or to schedule an appointment, please visit the program's website: bu.edu/sph/writing. If you have any questions, please contact the Program Manager, Ryann Monteiro at sphwrite@bu.edu.

Presentation Skills Appointments

Presentation skill appointments are available to SPH degree candidates looking to practice presentations and receive feedback from a peer coach on slides, poster presentations, speech outlines, and/or oral communication skills!

For more information or to schedule an appointment, please visit the program's website: bu.edu/sph/present. If you have any questions, please contact the Program Manager, Ryann Monteiro at sphwrite@bu.edu.

BUSPH Writing Guide

BUSPH Writing Guide (bu.edu/sph/writing-guide). The Guide includes components like writing strategies, communicating data, word choice, writing as a team, resources for non-native English speakers, and finding and using resources. In addition, there are explanations of several specific types of public health writing, including literature reviews, policy memos, reflections, and critiques. This Guide is designed to be a starting point for students and save you from having to answer basic questions about style and formatting.

BUSPH Library Tutorials

Librarians from the BU Alumni Medical Library created [BUSPH library tutorials](#), for students in the School of Public Health. The first is a brief overview of library resources followed by guidance on advanced searches using including PubMed, Web of Science, POPLINE, Google, etc. On this site you will also find tutorials on Mendelay and Zotero, which are free citation management programs, as well as on properly citing sources and avoiding plagiarism.

If you would like to make an appointment to meet with a librarian in person to get personalized assistance with a search you can contact them directly by email (refquest@bu.edu), phone (617 638-4228), or stopping by the reference desk on the 12th floor of the med school (Building L).